Red Thread Ties

Stars drop into the dark blue sky, making it ripple like it is the soft surface of a vast ocean. I stare at two purple falling stars dancing as they fly in the distance, lost in the waltz. Star trails, as vast as a vacuum, twirling like whirlpools, devour the space. As I turn my head, I see a whale swimming across the sky. It has fins with painted lines of glowing lights, killing my mind in the most beautiful way. I find myself standing on the roof of a skyscraper with my sister taking pictures beside me. Suddenly, the building crumbles down, sucking both of us toward the ground. I scream at the top of my lungs, gasping for air, grabbing onto falling pieces of concrete.

Part 1: room

I wake up screaming from dreaming. I breathe in loudly and my bed is creaking. The time is 3:34 am and my blood is rushing. It's so early, fuck, I can't show up looking dead to my meeting. I close my eyes and force myself back to sleeping. Breathe in, breathe out, and just stop thinking.

Have you ever had this feeling? You are awake at 3:56 am and you listen. Everything around you stops breathing as if nature is dead and peaceful, and all you can hear is the sound of you trying to inhale and exhale. As the clock strikes four and you are still wide awake, you wish to become one with nature, dead and peaceful. Instead, there is just the heavy noise of you breathing.

One more hour passes. I am still wrestling with my bed sheets, which make me feel too warm when I am under them and too cold when I am not. Suddenly, outside the window, the sun is rising up, slowly, and taunting me. How am I still awake? Why am I still awake? The alarm is

going off in 2 hours. I need the full eight hours of sleep. My body is tired, but here I am, lying awake. I am going to be late for my meeting. I won't be able to contribute anything to the meeting with a sleepy brain. Tears start falling down, one after another, each one heavier than the previous. Before I can get myself back together, I am sobbing in my room, gasping for air as if I am suffocating. I am suffocating.

This incident is the first-ever panic attack that I experienced. It slowly crept into my room and into my mind, and before I realized it, I was already devoured by it. It did not start there, nor would it end there. A red thread ties all these incidents together like fate, like in Japanese folklore. It is a thread that ties all these anxieties to me like we are destined lovers, and, the line goes long back into my past, tied to me in every room I got trapped in.

High school shuts down in a blink of an eye and before I know it, staying in my room and taking classes online become the new normal. Ties are cut between lovers and classmates who appeared as friends. Anxiety kicks in as the days come nearer toward trips, senior prom, graduation. The more it feels impossible to have a ceremony celebrating all these years I gave my sweat and tears for, the more obsessed I become with the idea of what could have happened if I am not stuck in this room. I romanticize the memories that never happened and the suits I never wore. A red tie around my neck never left.

Before I know it, it is February 1, 2021. I wake up to a morning disguised as a normal one by the chirping of birds and a ray of warm sunshine. I get out of my room to get breakfast and that is when I notice something is wrong. My phone is full of notifications. My grandfather is in distress. My mom is sobbing. Everything outside is quiet. Too quiet. When my mom finally finds her voice to tell me that this is a coup, my first reaction is being confused. This is

something I always imagined would be on the page of a history book. Am I dreaming? Is it possible for them to even do that? A red thread ties around my neck, getting tighter as the protests break out, as the businesses shut down, as the internet and phone lines get cut off, as the first shot pierces through a young girl's head, as the shootings begin, as two bullets ricochet into my house, one hitting the wall, one shattering the glass pane. We go back to my hometown to spend time with my father and escape the city where most shootings are happening. There I am, stuck in my room again, just watching people I know getting buried. Anxiety hangs there on my wall like a propaganda poster, saying, "You are next!"

Even after a year has passed, I still remember the first of February like it was yesterday, especially since the coup is still ongoing and the economy is failing. I tear up the last page of May and take a step into June as the summer holiday begins. Maybe it is the free time that curses me and my thoughts. Maybe it is the storm pouring down from the sky I once patched up with bandages. But, I find myself stuck in my messy dorm room, and there he is sitting in the corner, whispering to me things that could happen which are all out of my control. My thoughts wander in territories of what could happen to my friends and family, territories I would never even explore in my most honest writings. The articles from World Health Organization, screaming in my face that the anxiety prevalence rate has increased by 25% during/after the pandemic, do not make me feel any better. Almost every day, I wake up screaming from dreaming about all my anxieties. I encounter my first panic attack in twenty years, and another one in less than a month. Even when I escape my dreams, my sleep paralysis demons tie me down to my bed with red ribbons as a sacrifice for the lord himself. Every day, if I want, I can get out and leave, but I stay in the room where I am suffocating. I am suffocating.

A red thread ties to the moment when my friendships fell apart. A red thread ties to the moment they broke my heart. A red thread ties to all of my deadlines and due dates. A red thread ties to all of my regrets and my mistakes. A red thread ties to the songs I listened to block out the noise of my parents fighting. A red thread ties to the sound of my friends' mourning. A red thread ties to the moment my grandfather was diagnosed with cancer, and to the moment he passed away because no one could help him during the coup. A red thread ties to the times I did nothing because I hadn't got a clue. A red thread ties to the moment my dog got hit by a car after I left the country and I could not see her because my parents refused to send me a photo. A red thread ties to the moment I said "yes", but it was not love though. A red thread ties to the relationships I nurtured that ended up in death. A red thread ties to my place at the job I never loved. A red thread ties to the decision I made to follow someone to a party. A red thread ties to them shoving drugs up my nose, thinking they could love me. It ties to me wishing I got up right then and called a taxi. A red thread ties to a few months later when I could not get up from my bed because of an invisible force, a shadow creature, on my body, forcing itself on me, hugging me tight, and choking me from the neck down. A sleep paralysis, I discovered for the first time.

It is a puzzle to try and untie all the red threads in my present, past, and future. To my benefit, I am good at puzzles. And, puzzles are one of the keys to escaping all the red thread ties.

Part 2: escape

The more it feels impossible to have a ceremony celebrating all these years I gave my sweat and tears for, the more obsessed I become with the idea of what could have happened if I am not stuck in this room. It is at this moment that I decide to look around. During this

pandemic, the only way I can connect with my friends is online. So, we start playing online video games, especially puzzle games. While the outside world is burning out of our control, we find ourselves on a Discord call, laughing, screaming, and smiling as we successfully solve puzzle after puzzle. Gareth R. Jones and Jennifer M. George are correct about their research: As we solve more teamwork puzzles, we are developing high confidence and unconditional trust in each other and after a while, we feel more comfortable with asking for help when we are stuck. Not only do we talk about puzzles, but we also end up sharing our real-life struggles and end up giving life advice. Those moments feel like me trying to untie these red threads with the help of my friends. I am in love with every second we spend together fighting dragons, exploring dungeons, and interviewing aliens.

In the midst of the coup, I lost track of everything again. They cut off the internet lines and phone lines, so I am not able to reach my friends. There I am, stuck in my room again, just watching people I know getting buried. Anxiety stands there on my wall like a propaganda poster, saying, “You are next!” I look away from the posters, trying to find a distraction from my anxieties. That is when I turn to puzzles. This time they are not online video games; I find puzzles in real life whether it is from my old story books or riddle books. I spend most of my hours going through puzzle after puzzle because a mind at rest is a mind thinking about reality, and reality is not a great place to be stuck in right now. I choose to be stuck in my puzzles instead. In no time, I become proof of Lowney’s findings on puzzles where he suggested that they are great tools for diverting attention. When I run out of puzzles, I start to create them myself. I start dreaming about a better place. No. I start dreaming about a place where I am in control. I start creating scenarios in which I solve a puzzle and I escape.

One thing about diverting attention is that it is not always about trying to avoid something because as in Wegner's experiment with the white bear, the more one actively tries not to think about a subject, the more one thinks about it. It is about diverting attention from negative and intrusive thoughts about a subject that used to scare an individual and afterward, finding a comfortable way to think about it. This is necessarily important in my case because I cannot run away from the coup or the news forever. I have to face reality again. In no time, I find myself recreating some puzzles, sprinkling some aspects of reality on them, and making the final goal to escape the coup or something related. I divert my attention from anxieties and onto the puzzles. I cannot control the situation, but I can take control of my reactions. My emotions become more mature as I try to cope with the coup by creating puzzles and integrating them in a story where I have a chance to escape.

After a year has passed, a storm comes pouring down from the sky that I used bandages to patch up. I find myself stuck in my messy dorm room, and there he is sitting in the corner, whispering to me things that could happen which are all out of my control. I am in a new country. I escaped. But, my anxieties protest for the people I care about who are still in Myanmar. One sleepless night, I go through my phone looking for a reason to get out of my room, and I see something that sparks my interest. Escape Rooms. On the next day, I call my friends, book a room with the most interesting theme, and head out of my room. I do another the next week and one more three days after. No two rooms are the same and every room manages to offer me the element of surprise whether through technology or impressive puzzles or actors. Every surprise makes me feel refreshed and creates an expectancy violation which a clinical psychologist, Dr. Matthew Whalley, found was crucial in treating anxiety.

When I am doing escape rooms, it reminds me of the times I solved puzzles online with my friends, asking for help and tackling difficult situations together. But, solving the puzzles integrated into an environment/theme reminds me of the times I created situations and puzzles in my head to divert attention from the negativity-filled reality. I was telling stories in my head to cope with the coup, but escape rooms expand on this story-telling idea with grand decorations and technology. More than ever, I feel immersed, and warmly welcomed in by an adventure. I am with a team in an escape room, working towards a goal while solving puzzles. I get the best of both worlds in escape rooms, and more because of the immersive themes that are intriguing and therapeutic. Sometimes, I wish there are rooms with specific themes that reflect my life. Maybe it can be better if all puzzles are targeted because some puzzles give me more rush than others do. Nonetheless, I feel contempt. I can feel my progress each time I escape a room. I feel free coming out of an escape room. Free from anxieties and intrusive thoughts. Free from red thread ties. Free from the tied fate that always seems out of our control.

The red thread may still be tied to my future and lead me to situations and places out of my control, but now in the present, I escaped. In the midst of a dark storm, I am thankful for the escape I saw. I see…

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in the most beautiful way. I find myself standing on the roof of a skyscraper with my sister taking pictures beside me. I have never seen such a beautiful scene.

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